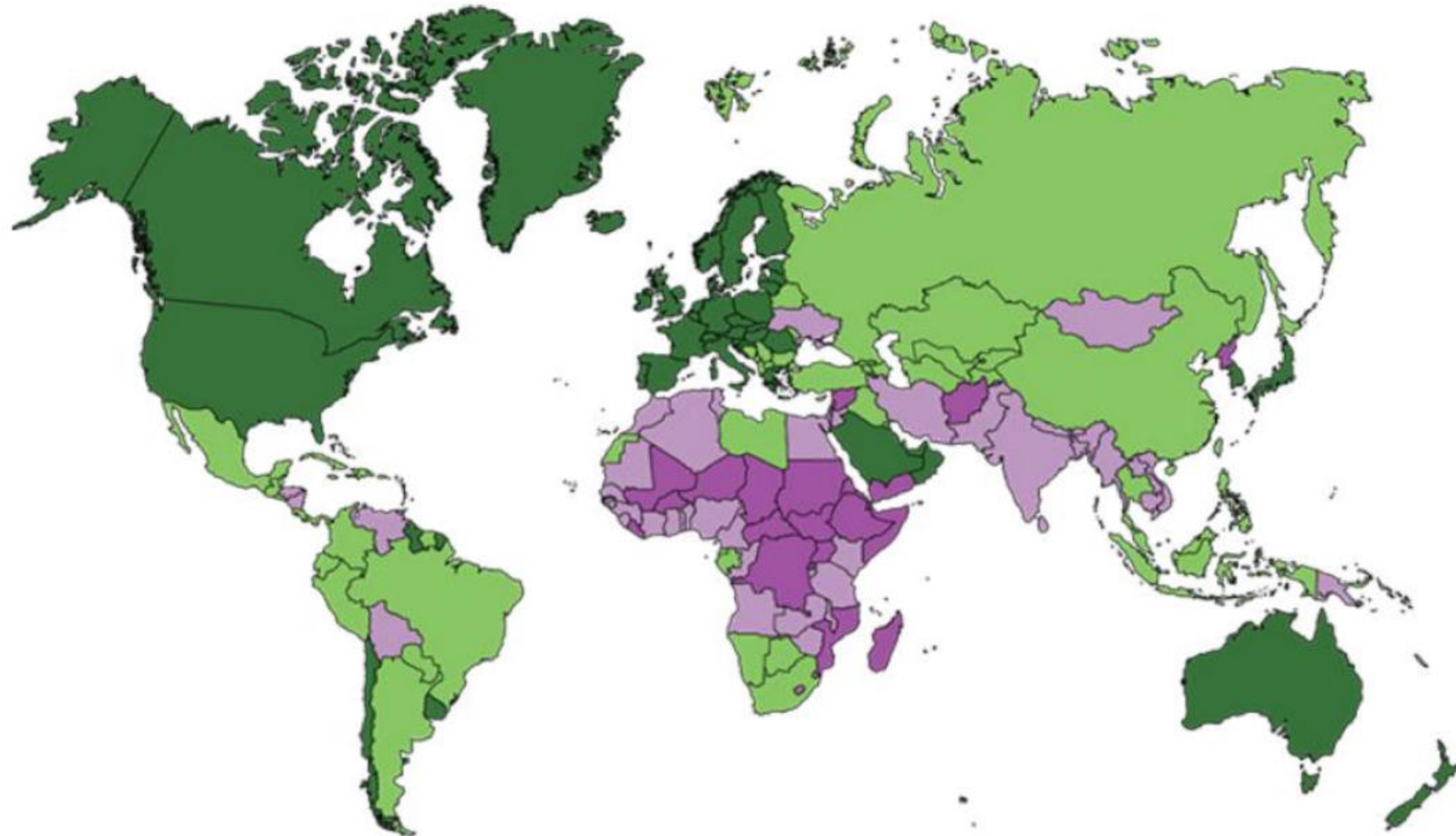


8.2 Uneven development

According to a 2024 Oxfam report on inequality, the world will have its first trillionaire in the next ten years, but poverty won't be eradicated for another 229 years. The world is developing unevenly, as shown in Source A. This map shows the world divided into a core of HICs, MICs, and LICs. This difference in the levels of development between HICs and LICs is called the **development gap**.

■ Low-income ■ Lower-middle income ■ Upper-middle income ■ High-income



Source A: The pattern of global development

Table 8.5: The three main groups of countries and their characteristics, based on World Bank classification

Low-income countries (LICs)	A group of around 26 countries. Classified by the World Bank as a country with a gross national income per capita of \$1135 or less in 2022. Agriculture plays an important role in their economies. Some of these countries suffer from political instability and conflict. Examples: Yemen, Chad, Democratic People's Republic of Korea, and Mozambique.
Middle-income countries (MICs)	A group of countries home to 75% of the world's population. Classified by the World Bank as a country with a gross national income per capita between \$1136 and \$13 845 in 2022. The number of MICs has increased rapidly in recent decades, linked to globalisation and investment by transnational corporations (see Topic 9). Examples: Mexico, Indonesia, Nigeria, Türkiye, and South Africa.
High-income countries (HICs)	A group of just over 80 countries. Classified by the World Bank as a country with a gross national income per capita of \$13 846 or more in 2022. In these countries, office work has overtaken factory work. Examples: Norway, Saudi Arabia, Japan, Uruguay, and Canada.

The distribution pattern for HICs, MICs, and LICs is complicated and changing constantly.

Key features are that:

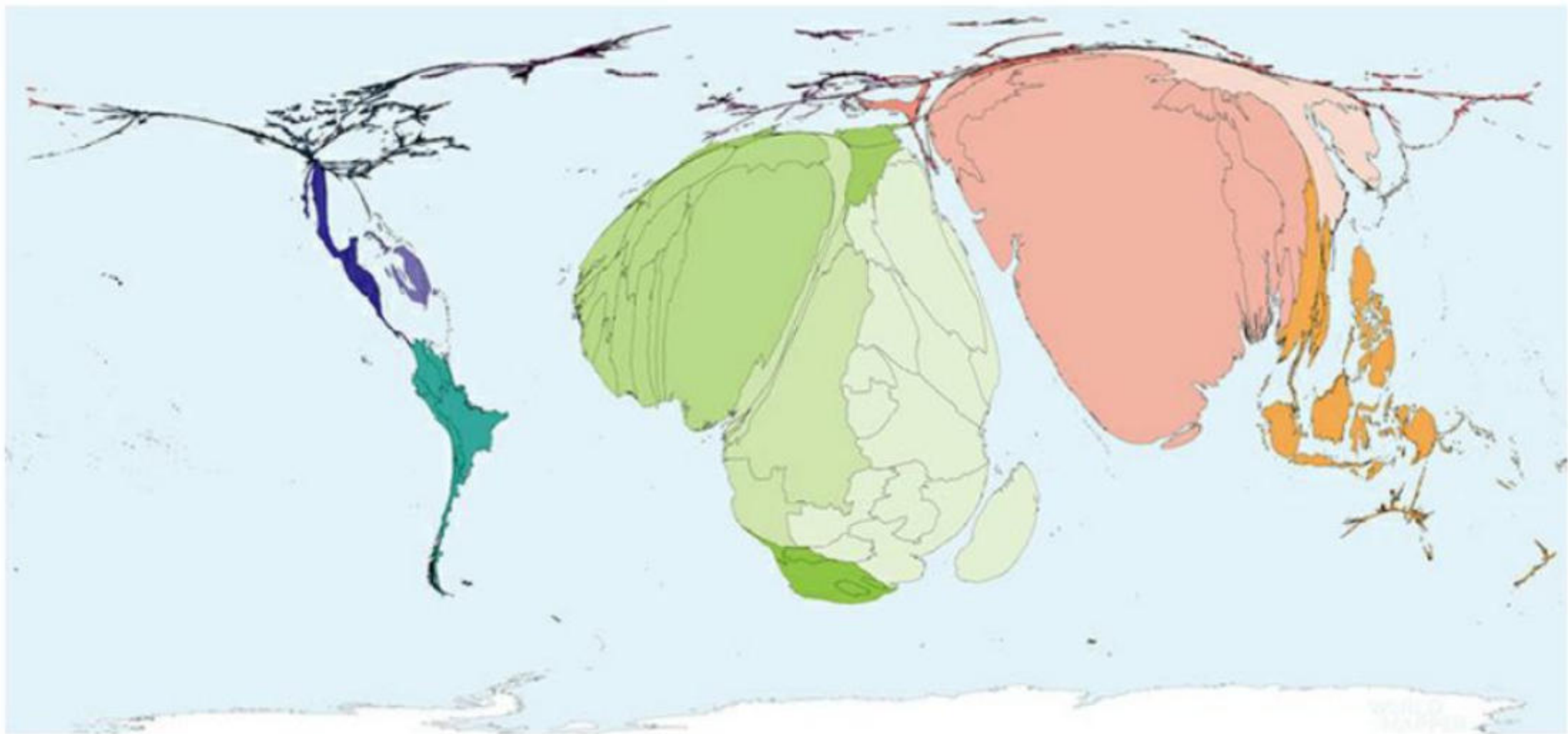
- most HICs and MICs are in the northern hemisphere
- most LICs are in the southern hemisphere
- most South American countries are MICs
- both Asia and Africa now have more MICs than LICs
- some Eastern European countries have been classified as MICs.

Remember the World Bank classification of countries presented in Table 8.5 is based on the average income of people living in that country. There are often stark variations in wealth within a country.

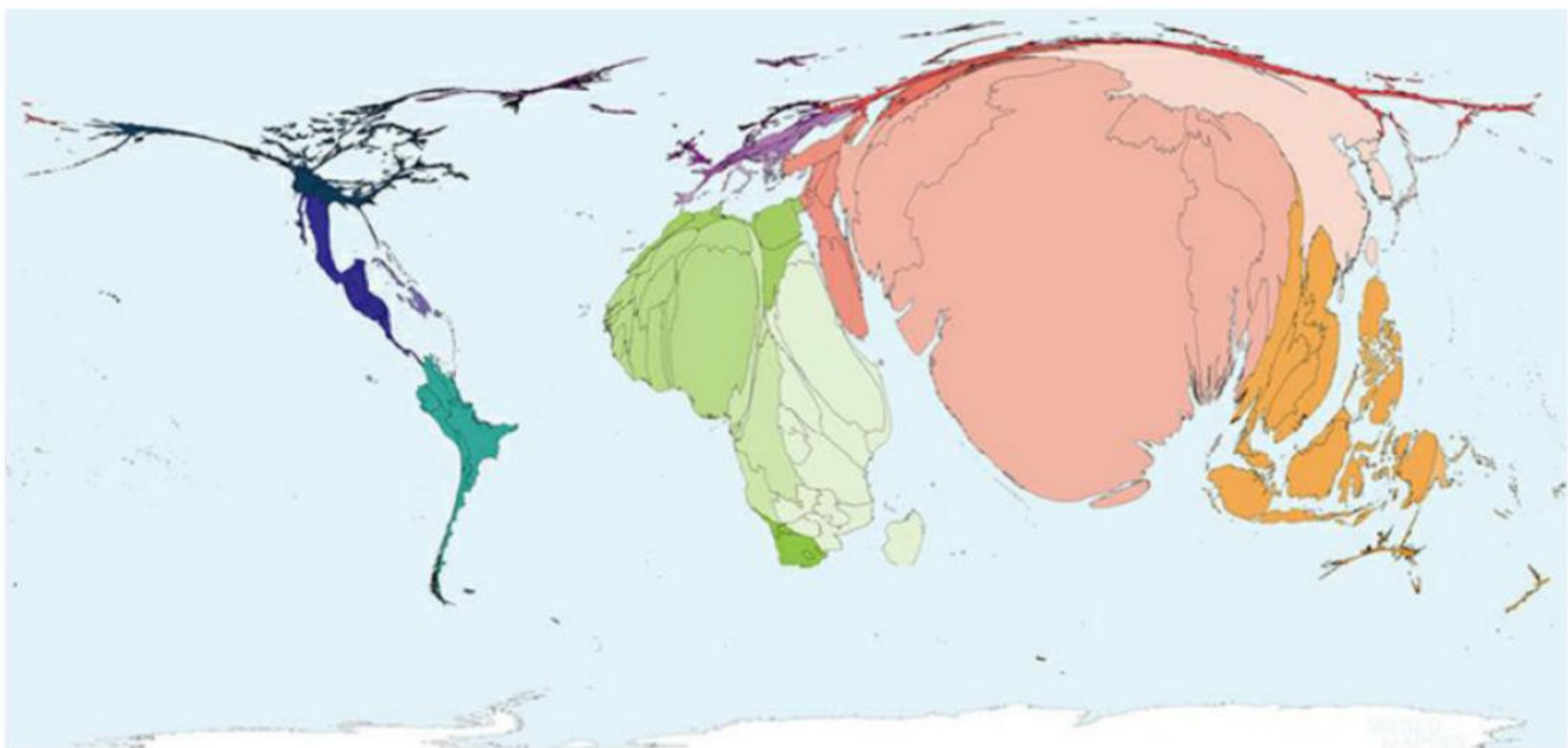
TASK 1: Study Source A

- a **Describe the pattern** of LICs, MICs, and HICs.
- b Suggest why MICs are making good progress along the **development pathway**.
- c The World Bank classification of countries is presented as a choropleth map. In pairs, discuss the advantages and disadvantages of this map presentation technique.

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Source **B**: A proportional map showing people living in absolute poverty



Source **C**: A proportional map showing underweight children in the world

TASK 2: Study Sources B C

- a Choose one of the two proportional maps. **Describe** and explain the pattern shown.
- b **Identify the similarities** between the maps. Are there any countries that surprise you? Discuss in pairs.

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

Inequality is an important concept in geography. Closing the development gap is a complex challenge. Think about who has the power and responsibility to help tackle this challenge? Individuals? Companies? Organisations? Governments? Can you think of the careers that geographers do that are related to

Reasons for differences in levels of economic development

There are various environmental, social, and economic reasons why countries have different rates and levels of development. The importance of these factors can change over time, and levels and rates of development do not stay the same.

Environmental factors

- Climate can play a significant role in levels of development. Countries with regular rainfall and moderate temperatures can usually grow enough food for their population. Many countries in Africa suffer from droughts. This means crops die and people lack enough food to eat. Some diseases, such as malaria, also thrive in hot climates. These illnesses can make people too weak to work.
- Nine of the twelve countries with the lowest HDIs are landlocked, meaning the country does not have access to the sea. These countries can find it difficult to trade with other countries as they are unable to export and sell goods by ship. On the other hand, natural features such as long coastlines, warm water ports, and natural harbours make trading easier.
- Natural disasters such as earthquakes, floods, and hurricanes occur more frequently in some countries. Money often has to be diverted to help with recovery and this impacts the development of the country.
- Some countries have natural resource wealth, such as minerals and fossil fuels. Some countries can extract and sell these resources to bring income and support development.



Figure 8.2: Climate plays a significant role in development. Droughts make it hard to grow crops to sell and feed the population.

Social factors

- Colonialism lasted for over 400 years, with European powers exploiting countries with natural resources. Colonies supplied food and resources to the country that had colonised them (for example, Brazil sent food and minerals to Portugal). This slowed the development of the colony but benefitted the development of the colonising country.
- Stable governments allow for resources to be allocated to larger-scale projects and services, such as health, education, and infrastructure. This can drive economic development. If a country is experiencing civil war, for example, then less money is being spent on these essential services for development.
- Some LICs have a large youthful population but a lack of education and/or employment opportunities. A lack of access to adequate healthcare, schools, and jobs significantly hinder economic growth.

Economic factors

- LICs often trade primary products relatively cheaply to HICs. The HIC then manufactures these primary products and sells the final product for a high profit.
- HICs have good infrastructure such as roads, railways, and electricity. This encourages foreign direct investment as businesses can benefit from relatively quick production and transport networks. This can help a country develop because it brings money into a country.

TASK 3

- a** In pairs, discuss and then agree a rank to show which of the above factors you think will have the most and least influence on the development of a country. Justify your final rank.
- b** Explain how political instability can have an influence on national wealth.
- c** Norway has a HDI of 0.961 compared with 0.394 for Niger. Which factors will have had an influence on the differences in the HDI scores of these two countries?